The Sims

By Lori Notaro

HUSBAND: What is that? "What IS THAT? What is that thing right near the fireman's foot in the front yard? Oh my God. Oh my God. What ... what have you done?!!

WIFE: Honestly, it really wasn't my fault. . . . I don't know, maybe it really was my fault. After all, after my husband bought me the computer game called "The Sims," the clerk at the Apple store was very careful to give me a stern warning as he handed my new game over.

CLERK: Now, since you get to create your own characters in this computer game, many people are tempted to duplicate themselves and their spouses. DON'T DO IT. No matter how tempted you are, DON'T DO IT. You'll almost always end up getting divorced.

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INTRODUCTION

"The Sims" is a fun simulation game that gets some parts of life right. We all get cranky if we don't have enough fun, food, and rest. But when it comes to marriage, the game is very different. Especially if Lori Notaro is the Grand Puppetmaster running the show. . . . Who said video addition can destroy a marriage? Sometimes it happens the first time you play! The Sims by Lori Notaro.

WIFE: For those of you unfamiliar with this game, briefly, this is the point: You create people, build houses for them, create a neighborhood, and watch how they coexist domestically and within the neighborhood. In short, it's like making your own soap opera, and you get to play the almighty deity and Grand Puppetmaster, I thought, this is a powerful game. I went immediately home and created a Laurie character and a Laurie's Husband character. I mean, it certainly was tempting to see what would happen between Laurie and Laurie's Husband when left to their

own devices-it was like watching an ant farm, in a sense, only the ants had human heads that looked like you and your husband. I mean, honestly, what was the worst that could happen?

After I created Laurie and Laurie's Husband, I moved them into a house and started the game. As Laurie and Laurie's Husband walked around in their house, it was my job to take them to the bathroom when they needed to pee, make sure they ate when they were hungry, make them take a shower when they got dirty, go to sleep when they got tired, and clean up after themselves. In short, it was like having an electronic pet, and to tell you the truth, I was not truly finding the game a whole lot of fun at all. Where was the action, where was the pull, the attraction to this game?

One thing is for sure, however; Laurie and Laurie's Husband were *pigs.* And I mean pigs! When she was done eating, she would simply throw the food on the floor, and one time I actually caught him leaving a turkey leg in the front yard. Okay, it's true, I gave him a mullet and armpit stains, but the last thing I expected was an automatic lapse into "Livin' in the Holler." Finally, I made them get jobs-which, in the Sims' world, is as easy as picking up the newspaper-but making sure that both of them were up, washed, dressed, and fed before the car pool came was nearly impossible. After I would wake up Laurie's Husband, I'd be getting her ready and off to work, only to find out that he went back to sleep,just like in *real* life. Eventually, after missing his ride to the office for three *days* in *a row because,* he lost his job. I could have told you that was going to happen.

Laurie, it was obvious, wasn't too happy with him, either. She came home from work, found the house buzzing with flies, him watching TV, a pile of turkey legs

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by the front door, and she started stomping her foot and shaking her fist at him. He retreated into the bedroom, where he sat on the edge of the bed, put his head in his hands, and began to sob.

Oh, this is ridiculous, I thought, so I decided that he definitely needed to get another job, one he was actually going to go to this time. So I made him get the newspaper, and then, to my surprise, he looked at me, a bubble came out of his mouth, and there were words inside it that said, "I don't want to look for a job right now. I am too depressed." And then he gave me a sad face.

Well, that may have worked in real life, buddy boy, but this is MY game and I AM THE GRAND PUPPETMASTER. I will do in my pretend universe what I apparently cannot do in reality! I command you to get a job!

HUSBAND: Who are you commanding to get a job now? Who is that fatty? Without the gut, he looks like Shaggy from Scooby-Doo."

WIFE: No. It's not Shaggy. It's you."

HUSBAND: Oh, great, you made me a barrel-shaped, Schlitzguzzling mechanic so I wouldn't cheat on you, huh? What is up with my hair? I look like a member of REO Speedwagon.

WIFE: I'm just trying to control my simulated universe.

HUSBAND: And who's that? That looks like Julia Roberts.

WIFE: Why, thank you, kind sir. That's not Julia Roberts, it's me!

HUSBAND: Why is the REO Speedwagon Shaggy crying?

WIFE: He's depressed. He lost his job and now he's too depressed to get another one.

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HUSBAND: Oh, he's not doing well. He needs to socialize, to clean up, and he's hungry. Maybe if you make him do those things, he'll be happy enough to get a job.

WIFE: It would be easier to slip him Prozac, but I'll try it.

HUSBAND: Maybe they can socialize and have fun while they make dinner together."

WIFE: My husband pulled up a chair next to mine and sat down. So I put Laurie and Mr. Sad Sack to work in the kitchen to interact and raise his spirits, and everything seemed to be going fine. I made her tickle him, which he liked, and then she told him some jokes. His "fun" level was rising, which was a very good sign. Laurie was making dinner, things were looking up, and at least he had stopped crying. I thought things were going well, until my husband pointed to the computer screen and said

HUSBAND: What's ... that?

WIFE: It took me at least a couple of seconds to realize it was a fire. Sad Sack had put the newspaper too close to the stove where Laurie was making dinner, and a small fire had erupted. And Laurie and Laurie's Husband were just standing there, watching it.

HUSBAND: Make them pick up the phone to call 911!

WIFE: I clicked on the phone, and clicked, and clicked, but neither one of them made a move. This was primarily because Sad Sack just shook his stupid head and gave me another sad face, and Laurie couldn't get to the phone, well, because she was now entirely engulfed in flames. I'm on FIRE! I'm on FIRE!! I searched the screen frantically for a garden hose or anything to put the fire out.

HUSBAND: Click on the flames and see if you get an option!

WIFE: Immediately, I clicked on the flames, and what popped up but the option to extinguish, and that's when Sad Sack finally coughed up a fire extinguisher

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and sprayed it all over the kitchen. The fire subsided. But it was too late. A computerized version of the Death March was heard, and when the fire extinguisher spray had cleared, Laurie was gone. Where she had stood just moments ago was now a small, gray urn. A message from the game popped up on the screen. "Laurie Notaro has died," the box said.

This is all his fault . . . . You! You just stood there as she sizzled like a Jimmy Dean sausage link!

HUSBAND: Click on the urn. Maybe there's a way to bring you back."

WIFE: So I clicked on the urn, but the only thing that happened was that an option to "mourn" popped up. So I took it. And then, a beautiful thing happened. Someone started to cry. Laurie's Husband wailed. I clicked on my urn again. Mourn. And again. Mourn. And again. Mourn. Cry, you big baby, cry! Look what you did to her! I'm going to keep you so depressed you'll never be able to get a job, have a normal life, or marry anyone else! He deserved it. You know he did.

That's when the fireman finally showed up, and Laurie's Husband moaned all the way out to the front yard to greet him as the fireman stood next to a bunch of decomposing turkey legs. "HOO HOO HOOOO!" I made him say to the fireman. "HOO HOO HOOOO!!"

HUSBAND: Come on, quit clicking on the urn. I've been through enough. Don't you want me to get on with my life? Hey, can we make a fake girl who looks like Kate Winslet?

WIFE: NO! I'm sorry, but did you or did you not just see me being incinerated like a

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Duraflame log? Huh? Did you? And then I clicked the urn numerous additional times to emphasize my point.

HUSBAND: What IS THAT? What is that thing right near the fireman's foot in the front yard? Oh my God. Oh my God. What ... what have you done?!!"

WIFE: And then I saw what my husband saw. A big, spreading puddle right at the tip of the fireman's boot.

HUSBAND: I hope you're happy! LOOK AT THAT. I've peed my pants!! I've wet myself in front of a fireman!"

WIFE: Yes, you certainly have.

HUSBAND: You were so busy making me cry and mourning you that you didn't bother to notice that my bladder needs were at alarming levels!

WIFE: Well, it's not my fault. Maybe if you realized you had to tinkle when I was a bonfire, I might still be alive!

HUSBAND: Actually, now that I'm thinking about it, I do need to use the rest room. And all of that mourning has made me hungry! What are we making for dinner?

WIFE: Not on your life!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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